

Field reference notes: channel comparison guide

What each channel shows

Channel	Shows	When
Visible	Reflected sunlight, cloud thickness and texture	Daytime only
Thermal infrared	Brightness temperature, cloud-top height	Day and night
Water vapour	Mid and upper-level moisture	Day and night

Identifying cloud

Visible	Infrared	Likely cloud
Bright	Very cold	Deep convection (cumulonimbus)
Bright	Warm	Low cloud or fog
Thin, grey	Cold	Cirrus

Patterns to know

- Monsoon: cloud bands along the monsoon trough.
- Tropical cyclone: central dense overcast, curved bands, eye in strong systems.
- Western disturbance: cloud band moving into north India in winter.